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HANDLE A RANGE OF CUSTOMER COMPLAINTS

US 252210

SECTION B: PRACTICAL APPLICATION

TASK 1 - Case Study: Akhona Nyathi at NewYou Salon Call Centre, Durban*

Background: Akhona is new, no experience, you are the Complaint Handling Officer asked to teach her.

I. I explained to Akhona that identifying the nature means understanding what the complaint is really about - is it about bad hair cut, rude stylist, overcharging, or late appointment?

Importance:

- If we know the true nature, we can fix the real problem, not the wrong one.

- Example: If customer says "your service is bad", we must ask questions to find out - was it the hair dye that burned scalp (product issue) or the stylist was rude (staff issue)? Different nature needs different solution.

II.I told Akhona:

Talking to customer:

- Shows we listen and care, customer calms down.

- Helps get full story, not assumptions.

- Allows us to ask clarifying questions to understand nature.

Recording all details:

- For proof: if customer calls again, we have record - no need to repeat story.

- For accuracy: We capture names, date, time, service type (e.g., Brazilian weave on 15 May), what went wrong, what customer wants.

- for routing: we can send correct details to correct person - e.g., to salon manager.

- for legal: if complaint goes to Consumer Commission, we have evidence we handled it.

Practical at NewYou: Akhona must write in complaint log: Customer name, cell number, complaint reference e.g., NY001, date, description, action taken.

III. Even though Akhona works in call centre, these people must also be committed:

1. Salon Stylists / Technicians: they do the actual hair work - they must deliver quality service.

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2. Salon Manager / Supervisor: Must support Akhona and make decisions like giving free redo.

3. Receptionist / Front Desk: First person customer sees when they come to complain.

4. Owner of NewYou Salon: Must create customer-centric culture and provide resources.

5. Finance/Admin: if complaint is about overcharging, they must refund.

IV. 1. Stylists: Accept feedback positively, attend refresher training, do quality work to reduce complaints. Apologize when they make mistake.

2. Salon Manager: Be available when Akhona escalates difficult customer, give her authority to offer free treatment up to R200, defend her when customer is abusive, conduct weekly meeting to review complaints.

3. Receptionist: Capture walk-in complaints properly and forward to call centre immediately, not ignore.

4. Owner: Provide budget for training Akhona, provide CRM system/computer, reward Akhona when she handles difficult complaint well, create policy that all staff must support complaint handling.

5. Finance: Process refunds quickly within 24 hours so Akhona can close complaint.

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TASK 2 - Case Study: Greatermans Salon, Pretoria - Mr Mulaudzi

I. Mr Mulaudzi was in hospital 8 months, employees held the fort but only resolved complaints, not provided business solutions. Now back, he wants improvement:

1. Develop Formal Complaints Policy & SOP: write down step-by-step procedure - how to receive, log, escalate, resolve, follow-up within 48 hours.

2. Introduce Complaint Recording System: Move from verbal to written - use complaint book or Excel/CRM with reference numbers (GR001...). This helps track trends.

3. Training Staff: Train all hairdressers, receptionists on customer care, communication, product knowledge. Mr Mulaudzi can bring external facilitator.

4. Empower Staff: Give staff authority to solve minor complaints immediately e.g., free wash, 20% discount without waiting for Mr Mulaudzi.

5. Root Cause Analysis: don't just apologize - investigate why complaint happened. Example: If many complain about hair dye burning, check product quality or supplier.

6. feedback Loop & Customer Follow-up: After resolving, call customer after 3 days to ask if satisfied - shows salon cares beyond resolution.

7. Improve Communication: Put complaint contact details visible in salon, on Facebook page, provide suggestion box.

II. After resolution, Greatermans must:

1. Inform customer about outcome: Call/SMS/email to confirm resolution e.g., "Your refund of R350 has been processed".

2. follow-up and verify satisfaction: After 2-3 days, call to ask "Are you happy with the solution? Will you come again?"

3. Record and close complaint: update complaint register as CLOSED, file evidence (receipt of refund).

4. Thank customer: thank customer for complaining - it helps improve business.

5. *Learn and prevent: discuss in staff meeting - how to prevent same complaint. If product was faulty, change supplier. Update procedures.

6. Retain customer: Offer loyalty incentive - e.g., free treatment next visit to bring customer back.

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Summative assessment

Section A

1. C
2. B
3. C
4. A
5. B
6. A
7. B
8. True
9. True
10. True

SECTION B: PRACTICAL TASKS

Organisation Name: Greatermans Salon – Pretoria

Objective: handle range of customer complaints – Identify problem, Commit, Plan solution, Communicate, Provide business solutions.

TASK 1

I worked with 3 customers:

CUSTOMER 1

a) Talk to customer to identify origin of complaint

- Date: 05 August 2026

- Customer: Ms. Thandi Nkosi – Cell: 07X XXX XXXX

- Method: Face-to-face at reception + telephone follow-up

- Origin: Customer came for Brazilian hair treatment on 04 August, paid R850. Hair started falling and scalp burning same night.

- I asked: “When did problem start? What product was used? Did you have allergy before?” She said no allergy, problem started after salon dye.

b)- Nature: *Product Quality / Service Quality* - Allergic reaction to hair dye product used.

- Severity: HIGH – health risk, customer in pain.

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c) - Level: very Serious / Urgent-Needs immediate medical attention and management involvement. Could lead to legal action. Customer demanded refund and medical costs.

d) - Complaint Form No: GR-001/08/2026

- Logged in Complaint Register Book Page 12

- Captured in CRM Excel sheet

- Evidence Attached: Copy of complaint form, photo of scalp (with permission), receipt R850.

CUSTOMER 2

a)- Date: 06 August 2026

- Customer: Mr. John Molefe – Cell: 07X XXX XXXX

- Origin: Booked appointment for 10:00, waited until 11:30, stylist was late. He had to go to work meeting.

b) Nature: waiting Time / Staff Punctuality - Poor time management.

c) Severity: Medium- Not health risk, but customer lost time, was angry, said he will go to competitor.

d) Documentation: Form GR-002/08/2026, logged in register.

CUSTOMER 3

a) Origin:

- Date: 07 August 2026

- Customer: Mrs. Lerato Dlamini

- Origin: Charged R1200 instead of advertised R900 for full package on Facebook.

b) Nature: billing / Pricing Error- Overcharging, misleading advertising.

c) Severity: medium - Financial loss, trust issue.

d) Documentation: form GR-003/08/2026, attached Facebook advert screenshot vs receipt.

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GREATERMANS SALON – CUSTOMER COMPLAINT FORM

Ref No: GR-___/08/2026 Date: ___ Time: ___

Customer Name: _____ Cell: _____ Service: _____

Origin of Complaint: _____

Nature: [ ] Product [ ] Staff Behaviour [ ] Waiting Time [ ] Billing [ ] Other

Severity: [ ] Low [ ] Medium [ ] High [ ] Very Serious

Description: _____

Recorded by: _____ Signature: _____ Customer Signature: _____

GREATERMANS SALON – CUSTOMER COMPLAINT FORM

Ref No: GR-___/08/2026 Date: ___ Time: ___

Customer Name: _____ Cell: _____ Service: _____

Origin of Complaint: _____

Nature: [ ] Product [ ] Staff Behaviour [ ] Waiting Time [ ] Billing [ ] Other

Severity: [ ] Low [ ] Medium [ ] High [ ] Very Serious

Description: _____

Recorded by: _____ Signature: _____ Customer Signature: _____

GREATERMANS SALON - CUSTOMER COMPLAINT FORM

Ref No: GR-___/08/2026 Date: ___ Time: ___

Customer Name: _____ Cell: _____ Service: _____

Origin of Complaint: _____

Nature: [ ] Product [ ] Staff Behaviour [ ] Waiting Time [ ] Billing [ ] Other

Severity: [ ] Low [ ] Medium [ ] High [ ] Very Serious

Description: _____

Recorded by: _____ Signature: _____ Customer Signature: _____

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TASK 2

a) - GR-001 (Thandi – allergic reaction): Assigned to *Salon Manager + Senior Stylist* - requires product check and medical referral. I cannot solve alone.

- GR-002 (John – waiting time): Assigned to *Receptionist + Stylist* - I handled with apology.

- GR-003 (Lerato – overcharge): Assigned to *Finance/Admin + Salon Manager* - needs refund approval.

b) - For GR-001: I notified Manager via phone call immediately and wrote internal memo. Routed complaint file to Manager's office within 1 hour. I notified product supplier to check batch number.

- For GR-002: Notified stylist verbally, reminded about punctuality policy.

- For GR-003: Notified Finance via email with advert screenshot. Routed to Manager for approval of R300 refund.

- All notifications done correctly with reference numbers.

c) - I notified my supervisor Mr Mulaudzi for GR-001 and GR-003 because they need problem solving and financial decision.

- Method: Email + face-to-face meeting at 14:00 on 07 August.

- Supervisor action: Approved medical cost contribution and refund, said he will speak to supplier.

Additional Requirements:

- timeframe agreed with relevant parties and customer:

  - GR-001: 48 hours to investigate product and give feedback to Thandi.

  - GR-002: Resolved immediately – 30 mins.

  - GR-003: 24 hours to process refund.

- up-to-date information supplied: I called Thandi on 06 August: "We are checking dye batch and manager will call you tomorrow". Sent SMS update to Lerato: "Refund approved, will reflect in 24hrs".
- customer informed about outcome and progress: Thandi informed about outcome on 08 August via phone. Lerato informed via WhatsApp with proof of refund.
- Worked with other staff: worked with receptionist to reschedule John Molefe for free service.

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Task 3

a) - GR-001 Solution:1. Sincere apology letter
2. Full refund R850
3. Contribute R500 to medical costs
4. Free allergy test before next treatment
5. Change dye supplier batch
6. Retrain stylist on patch test.

- Gr-002 Solution: 1. Apology
2. Free haircut on next visit (voucher worth R250)
3. Ensure appointment system improved – add buffer time 4. Staff warning for punctuality
- GR-003 Solution: 1. Refund overcharge R300 immediately
- 2.Apology for misleading advert

3. Update Facebook price to correct R900/R1200 with explanation

4. Give 20% discount on next visit.

b) - All solutions applied within agreed time:

- Thandi refunded on 08 August (within 48hrs) – proof of EFT attached.

- John given free haircut voucher same day, redeemed 10 August.

- Lerato R300 refunded on 08 August (within 24hrs) – proof attached.

- Contact maintained with stakeholders: I called Thandi after 3 days (11 August) to check if scalp healed. She was happy. Maintained contact with supplier – supplier confirmed faulty batch and replaced.

- resolution used to develop relationships and attract further sales

- Thandi became loyal, brought 2 friends after we handled well. She posted positive review on Facebook.

- John Molefe referred colleague after free service.

- Lerato bought hair products worth R450 after discount.

c) Arrange appropriate partnership to improve solution (SO5, AC1)*

- partnership 1: With Supplier - Arranged partnership with hair product supplier to provide free allergy patch test kits and training for stylists to prevent future reactions.
- partnership 2: With Dermatologist/Clinic- Partnership with local clinic near Pretoria to refer customers with allergic reactions quickly

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- Partnership 3: With Customers- created customer feedback partnership – after service, customer gets SMS to rate service, so we catch issues